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Oshkosh ends Flock Safety contract but will keep license plate readers

The Oshkosh Common Council ended its subscription with Flock Safety at the recommendation of the police chief, but the city plans to keep the technology through a new vendor.

By: Hayden Bailey

Posted

OSHKOSH (NBC 26) — Last week, the Oshkosh Common Council ended the city's contract with the automated license plate reader company Flock Safety. However, the technology is still expected to stay in the city through a new vendor.

The Common Council first approved the use of Flock Safety cameras in 2022. The city's Flock Safety subscription ended at the recommendation of Oshkosh Chief of Police Dean Smith.

Dr. Matt Richie, an associate professor of criminal justice at UW-Oshkosh, said residents are concerned.

"I think there is more scrutiny about it. People are more concerned about it. They are recognizing that this is a loss of privacy," said Richie, "The case law is clear, you do have a reduced expectation of privacy on the road. How much that reduction is, I think we're finding that now."

Watch the full broadcast story here:

I reached out to fellow Scripps journalist Maggie Bryan, who saw the same thing happen in Denver, Colorado.

"There's been a lot of controversy in Denver over flock safety. We recently switched to a new provider for license plate recognition cameras, a new provider called Axon," said Bryan, "Denver police, they use Axon for a lot of different things already. Body cameras, the tasers they use, Evidence.com, and now license plate recognition technology."

Some residents, however, still express a desire for strengthened public safety.

"Flock cameras. I believe we need more of those in the area because there's a lot of crime that's been around for quite some time, and I feel like it's getting worse by the

day," said local musician Lamar, also known as Lil L.A. Marz.

"There's kidnappers around the area. There's people that do unspeakable crimes."

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